



Grizzly bear

Ursus arctos horribilis

All grizzlies are brown bears, but not all brown bears are grizzlies. This subspecies gets its name from its light-tipped fur, yet not all are “grizzled”—their coats range from whitish-blond to almost black. Their shoulder “hump” consists of muscles that make them efficient diggers and capable of inflicting strong blows with their forepaws.

Despite its often fearsome reputation, the bulk of a grizzly bear’s diet comprises nuts, grasses, roots, seeds, and moths. Much of the meat they eat comes from carrion, but they hunt mammals ranging from ground squirrels to moose. Grizzlies prefer coniferous forests broken by fields and meadows with access to rivers. Good swimmers, they are skilled at catching trout, bass, and salmon.

Grizzly threat

Grizzlies mate in late spring to early summer. The female gives birth to up to four cubs, usually while hibernating, nursing them in her den until April or May. Cubs stay with their mothers for two to four years, and the main threat to youngsters is from adult male grizzlies. Once common throughout the western US, grizzlies now occur in small numbers only in Idaho, Montana, Washington state, and Wyoming, with larger populations in Alaska and Canada.



- ↔ 5–8 ft (1.5–2.4 m)
- 🏠 132–727 lb (60–330 kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌿 Berries, roots, carrion, fish
- 🏠



NW. North America



△ FOOD FIGHT

Grizzlies are powerful bears and competition for the best fishing spot can cause a fight to break out. However, most will stop before a serious injury occurs.

◁ WHO'S THE DADDY?

Female grizzlies will mate with several males in a breeding season and the cubs in the resulting litter may have different fathers.